That charter may be imperfect, but was forged to contain precisely the fault lines violent politics reopens, whether federalism, affirmative action, language or citizenship." The safer path is to work within the constitution and retain parliamentary oversight—even if truncated—for an interim period. As one source put it: "If they work within the present constitution, things will be smoother."

WHAT IT MEANS FOR INDIA

Any turmoil within Nepal inevitably spills over across its 1,770-km open border that abuts five Indian states—Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Sikkim and West Bengal. New Delhi's instinct so far has been restraint. After a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security, Prime Minister Narendra Modi issued a carefully worded message in English, Hindi and Nepali, calling the violence "heart-rending", mourning the young dead, and urging peace. The goal is clear: engage quietly, avoid the "we fixed it" optics that fuel anti-India narratives, and keep critical cooperation such as in trade, energy, connectivity on track. "India should counsel quietly on issues such as peace, engagement, trade, and avoid grandstanding," says Ranjit Rae.

The border map dispute over the territorial rights of Lipulekh, Kalapani, Limpiyadhura at the trijunction of India, Nepal and China remains an irritant since Kathmandu's 2020 cartographic assertion and New Delhi's rejection. The issue escalated when Nepal published a new political map claiming these areas, citing the 1816 Sugauli Treaty, which defines the Kali River as the western boundary. Nepal claims the river originates west of Kalapani, placing the disputed land within its territory. India asserts that the river originates further east, making it part of Uttarakhand. Tensions flared after India inaugurated a road to the Lipulekh Pass in May 2020. Nepal called it a violation of sovereignty; India dismissed the claims, calling the area its own. For Oli, long known for calibrating nationalist rhetoric under India's shadow while courting China, the border dispute offered a perfect opportunity for domestic mobilisation. "Once you finger things cartographically, it lingers. Maps become an agenda item you either have to cross, look the other way or deal with. Oli crossed the red line, as anti-Indianism gets votes," Puri points out.

In his earlier stint as PM, Oli had irked India first by signing a transit pact with Beijing in 2016, then the Belt and Road Initiative papers in 2017, and sought fresh optics in 2024—even as many BRI projects stalled. New Delhi read Oli's tilt warily; Kathmandu saw it as leverage. But most of Nepal's urgent needs such as power sales, ports, pipes, medicine, education can best be met by India. Also, maps alone do not make neighbours, people do. An estimated two million Nepalis live and work in India, crossing the frontier daily and the armies of the two countries have shared uniforms under the Gorkha crest. This human interface is the best guardrail against geopolitical opportunism and the best reason for everyone, in Kathmandu and New Delhi, to tread carefully.

FOR INDIA, THE GOAL IS CLEAR: ENGAGE QUIETLY, AVOID THE 'WE FIXED IT' OPTICS THAT FUEL ANTI-INDIA NARRATIVES AND KEEP TIES IN TRADE, ENERGY AND CONNECTIVITY ON TRACK

One casualty of the current chill is the historic Gorkha bond. Nepal's decision to pause participation in India's Agniveer scheme snapped an artery-deep link. "It's a big setback... a very important pillar of our relationship," said an expert, noting that earlier, there were roughly 1,300 recruits annually into the Indian Army and 125,000 retired servicemen in Nepal. Kathmandu's quiet fear, he explained, is that short-term trained soldiers returning into a fragile milieu could raise the violence potential. It is a fear sharpened by memories of the Maoist insurgency. Delhi hears another note: a friend stepping away at a sensitive time.

China's role is less immediate than many assume but never absent. "Remember money talks—China has it, and governments listen," an analyst says. In moments of vacuum, he warns, cheque books can speak louder than words. Yet the current storm is not a geopolitical set-piece; it is a crisis of domestic legitimacy, made visible on digital screens and burnt buildings. Geography, however, demands that Nepal maintain a positive relationship with India. Trade between India and Nepal amounted to $8.5 billion, with the balance tilted heavily in

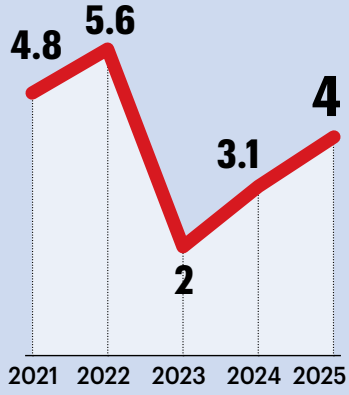
GROWTH PANGS

Nepal's economy remains modest in size; after a brief post-pandemic rebound, growth momentum has slowed

$46.8 bn
GDP in 2025; 100th position globally

$1,469
GDP per capita in 2025, half that of India's

REAL GDP GROWTH RATE (%)*



*based on constant local currency

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY